10th Class English • Unit 7 • Punjab Board (New Syllabus 2026)

Time — Percy Bysshe Shelley

Fully solved exercises: stanza explanation, comprehension, MCQs, glossary, central idea and mind map, precis, punctuation and hyphenation, metaphor and analogy, panel discussion

A. The Poem at a Glance

Poet: Percy Bysshe Shelley (1792–1822), an English Romantic poet known for "Ozymandias", "To a Skylark" and "Prometheus Unbound". **Type:** a short lyric poem written as an **apostrophe** — the poet speaks directly to time. **Metre:** irregular, without a fixed rhyme scheme, because the sea itself has no regular pattern.

Central idea: time is an **unfathomable sea** — vast, deep, shoreless and cruel. Its waves are years, its water is mixed with human tears, and it swallows every human life. Man cannot sail on it or control it; he can only be carried by it towards death.

The poem in short:

"Unfathomable Sea! whose waves are years, / Ocean of Time, whose waters of deep woe / Are brackish with the salt of human tears! / Thou shoreless flood, which in thy ebb and flow / Claspest the limits of mortality! / And sick of prey, yet howling on for more, / Vomitest thy wrecks on its inhospitable shore; / Treacherous in calm, and terrible in storm, / Who shall put forth on thee, / Unfathomable Sea?"

Part of the poem	What it means
Lines 1–3	Time is a sea too deep to measure; its waves are years, and its water is bitter and salty because it is mixed with the tears of suffering humanity.
Lines 4–5	It is a flood without any shore, and in its rising (flow) and falling (ebb) it holds the whole boundary of human life — birth, growth, decline and death.
Lines 6–7	It is like a monster "sick of prey" — tired of what it has eaten — yet still "howling on for more", and it throws up the wrecks of human lives on the inhospitable shore of death.
Lines 8–10	"Treacherous in calm, and terrible in storm" — time is most dangerous when it looks peaceful. The poem ends with a rhetorical question: nobody can safely sail on this sea.

B. Question Given Beside the Poem

1. “Unfathomable Sea!” What do these lines suggest about the nature of the sea?

The phrase presents the sea as something whose depth can never be measured — unfathomable means impossible to understand or measure. So the sea of time is suggested as **vast and mysterious** (no one can see the bottom), **uncontrollable** (the sea does what it wishes), **destructive** (it howls, it vomits wrecks) and **deceptive** (treacherous in calm). It is also **shoreless**, that is, without limits, so there is no land of safety anywhere. The tone is one of awe and helplessness rather than of beauty.

C. Glossary — Words and Meanings

Word	Meaning
brackish	containing both salt and fresh water; somewhat salty
claspest	holds tightly, embraces or encircles (old form of “clasp”)
ebb	the outward flow of the tide; a decline or decrease
howling	making a loud, mournful cry or sound
shoreless	without a shore; having no boundary or end
treacherous	dangerous or deceitful
unfathomable	impossible to understand or measure
vomitest	throws up or disgorges, often in a forceful manner (old form of “vomit”)
woe	great sorrow or distress

Note the old second-person endings -est / -eth (claspest, vomitest): they belong to the grand, archaic style in which the poet addresses the sea.

questions

1. What does the “unfathomable sea” symbolise in the poem?

It symbolises **time itself** — a force that is too deep and too vast for the human mind to measure or understand. Its “waves are years”, so every year that passes is only one wave of this sea. It also symbolises **human sorrow and mortality**, because its water is salty with human tears and it “claspest the limits of mortality”. In short, the sea stands for the endless, uncaring flow of time that carries every generation to death.

2. What words or phrases show time's power over human lives?

(i) “whose waves are years” — the passage of life itself is in the hands of time; **(ii)** “shoreless flood” — it has no boundary and cannot be escaped; **(iii)** “claspest the limits of mortality” — birth and death are held inside it; **(iv)** “sick of prey, yet howling on for more” — it hunts human beings and is never satisfied; **(v)** “vomitest thy wrecks on its inhospitable shore” — it throws away the broken lives it has destroyed; **(vi)** “treacherous in calm, and terrible in storm” — it is dangerous in every mood. All these are images of power, not of partnership.

3. How does the image “shoreless” contribute to the overall meaning of the poem?

“Shoreless” means having no shore, no boundary and no end. It adds three ideas to the poem. **First, infinity:** time cannot be measured or reached, exactly like a sea without a coast. **Second, helplessness:** a swimmer needs a shore to reach; if there is no shore, there is no safety, no rest and no escape for man. **Third, it strengthens the last line:** if the sea has no shore, then the question “Who shall put forth on thee?” already has its answer — nobody. The word turns a picture into a verdict on human life.

4. How is mortality connected to the “ebb and flow” of time?

The ebb and flow is the rising and falling of the tide. Human life follows the same movement: a person rises in youth, stands at his height in middle age, and declines towards death, exactly as the tide comes in and goes out. The phrase “in thy ebb and flow / Claspest the limits of mortality” means that the whole span of a human life — its beginning and its end — is held inside the movement of time. The ebb in the glossary also means “a decline or decrease”, which is precisely what death is. So mortality is not separate from time; it is a wave of time's sea.

5. What is the tone of the poem? How does Shelley use language to create this tone?

The tone is **dark, awe-filled, mournful and fearful** — the tone of a man standing at the edge of a stormy ocean. Shelley creates it by **(i) harsh, sorrowful vocabulary** — “woe”, “tears”, “howling”, “vomitest”, “wrecks”, “inhospitable”, “treacherous”, “terrible”; **(ii) the apostrophe** “Unfathomable Sea!” with exclamation marks, which shows strong emotion; **(iii) personification** of time as a hungry beast; **(iv) the old, solemn forms** “claspest” and “vomitest”, which give the poem the sound of a prayer or a curse; and **(v) a closing rhetorical question**, which leaves the reader with no answer and therefore with fear.

6. How does Shelley personify time in the poem?

Shelley speaks to time as if it were a living person and then describes it as a living monster. It is addressed directly as “Thou shoreless flood” and “thee”, it **clasps** like a hand, it is **sick of prey** like a beast, it **howls on for more** like a hungry wolf, it **vomits** wrecks, and it is **treacherous** like a false friend. By giving time these human and animal qualities, the poet turns an abstract idea into a creature we can fear, which is exactly what personification is for.

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7. Why does Shelley use the word “brackish” to describe the waters of time?

“Brackish” means water that is salty and unpleasant to drink. The poet says the waters of time are “brackish with the salt of human tears”, which means that sorrow is mixed into the very substance of time: every hour of life contains some grief, and the years have made the sea salty. The word also suggests that the water cannot give life — a traveller on it can never drink and be refreshed. So a single word carries the whole pessimistic message of the poem: time is not fresh water but salt tears.

8. What role does the “howling” of time play in the poem?

The howling gives the poem a **sound**, and that sound makes the reader hear time as well as see it. It shows that time is like a wild animal crying for food: it has swallowed whole generations and is “sick of prey”, yet it still howls for more. So the word shows **greed, restlessness and cruelty**, it creates a frightening atmosphere, and it prepares the reader for the helpless question at the end — who can sail on a sea that howls?

9. What does the final line suggest about humanity's relationship with time? What might Shelley be trying to convey through this question?

The final line — “Who shall put forth on thee, / Unfathomable Sea?” — is a rhetorical question whose answer is “nobody”. It suggests that the relationship of man with time is one of complete helplessness: no ship, no science and no prayer can sail on this sea or command it. Shelley conveys two things through the question. **First**, he warns the reader not to be proud, because every human plan is a small boat on an infinite ocean. **Second**, he invites us to accept our mortality with awe rather than with anger, and to use the little time we have with humility.

10. How does Shelley develop the central idea of time's power and unpredictability throughout the poem, and what supporting images or metaphors does he use?

The central idea is that time is a powerful, uncontrollable force that affects all humanity, and Shelley develops it in three movements. **First movement (depth and size):** he calls time an “unfathomable sea” and a “shoreless flood”, so the reader first feels its greatness. **Second movement (cruelty):** he makes the water brackish with human tears and shows time as a beast “sick of prey, yet howling on for more” which “vomitest” the wrecked lives on an inhospitable shore — now the reader feels its cruelty. **Third movement (deception and helplessness):** time is “treacherous in calm, and terrible in storm”, and the poem closes with the question “Who shall put forth on thee?”, which leaves man with no answer. The supporting images are therefore the **sea**, the **waves/years**, the **tears/salt**, the **beast of prey** and the **wrecks on the shore**, and together they move the idea from greatness to cruelty to total helplessness.

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E. Choose the Correct Option (MCQs) — solved with key

1. What metaphor does Shelley use to describe time in the poem?

river mountain
unfathomable sea endless sky

Answer: unfathomable sea — The whole poem is built on the metaphor "Ocean of Time".

2. In the poem, the "shoreless flood" symbolises:

the end of life the calmness of time
the unpredictable nature of time the boundaries of time

Answer: the unpredictable nature of time — A flood without a shore has no limits and cannot be predicted or escaped.

3. What emotion is most strongly conveyed by the word "brackish" in the context of the poem?

joy indifference
grief hope

Answer: grief — Brackish water is salty with human tears, so it carries sorrow.

4. The "howling" of time in the poem suggests:

the joy of passing moments the destructive and relentless nature of time
the calmness of eternity the beauty of the present

Answer: the destructive and relentless nature of time — Time howls for more prey even when it is sick of prey.

5. What does the word "treacherous" imply about time in the poem?

Time is steady and reliable. Time is comforting and gentle.
Time is dangerous and deceptive. Time is forgiving.

Answer: Time is dangerous and deceptive — Treacherous means deceitful — dangerous especially in its calm.

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F. Central Idea, Mind Map and Precis

Central idea: time is a vast, uncontrollable and destructive force that governs the whole life of man and ends in death; human beings can neither measure it nor fight it.

Branch of the mind map	Details from the poem
The sea (metaphor)	"unfathomable sea", "ocean of time", "shoreless flood"
Its waves	"whose waves are years" — passing of years
Its water	"brackish with the salt of human tears" — sorrow in every hour

Branch of the mind map	Details from the poem
Its power	“claspest the limits of mortality” — birth and death are inside time
Its cruelty	“sick of prey, yet howling on for more”, “vomitest thy wrecks”
Its deception	“treacherous in calm, and terrible in storm”
Man's position	“Who shall put forth on thee?” — total helplessness
Tone	dark, awe-filled, mournful; exclamations and a rhetorical question

A mind map is written as branches from one centre — here the centre is “TIME = Unfathomable Sea”. It shows at a glance that every image in the poem supports one single idea.

Precis of the poem (2–3 sentences)

Shelley compares time to an unfathomable, shoreless sea whose waves are years and whose water is salty with human tears. This sea holds the whole span of human life and destroys generation after generation, howling for more prey and throwing up the wrecks of human lives on a hostile shore. Because it is treacherous in calm and terrible in storm, no human being can sail upon it or control it.

Spelling

Item	Rule	Example
Capitalization	Capital letter for the first word of a sentence, proper nouns, days, months, titles and the pronoun “I”	Time waits for no one.
Punctuation	Full stop, comma, exclamation mark, question mark, quotation marks, dash and hyphen make the meaning clear	Do you know what time it is?
Spelling	The correct arrangement of letters in a word	Tomorrow is Wednesday.

A. Write a short paragraph (4–5 lines) describing what time means to you. Use correct capitalization, punctuation and spelling.

Model answer:

To me, time is the most honest teacher in the world. It never argues and never waits; it simply moves, and it shows at the end what I really was. In the month of December, when examinations come, I feel that time is a train that will not stop at my station twice. I have learnt to respect it: I make a small timetable every Sunday, and I try to keep it honestly. Time, I believe, is not money but life itself, and a wasted hour never comes back.

Hyphenation conventions

A **hyphen** (-) joins words or parts of words to make the meaning clear: compound adjectives before a noun (“a well-known voice”, “a twenty-minute break”) and compound nouns (“check-in”, “mother-in-law”). It is also used to split a long word at the end of a line.

B. Can you identify or rewrite a line from “Time” using a hyphenated compound adjective? For example, could “fast flying bird” be written as “fast-flying bird”? What effect does this change have?

Rewritten: “Time is a **fast-flying** bird that never waits for the hand that tries to hold it.”

Effect: with the hyphen, “fast-flying” becomes one adjective describing the bird, so the reader understands at once that the bird is fast in its flying. Without the hyphen, “fast flying bird” can be misread as “a fast bird that is flying” or even as two separate ideas. So the hyphen removes confusion, tightens the rhythm of the line and gives the image a sharper, more poetic finish.

Transitions and varied syntax

C. Choose two lines or ideas from “Time”. Write a short paragraph connecting them using at least two transitions and two different sentence structures.

In “Time”, Shelley first presents time as an “unfathomable sea”, and he then shows the same sea howling for more prey. **As a result**, the reader understands that time is not a quiet measurement but a hungry force. **Moreover**, the poet calls it “treacherous in calm”, which means that its peaceful moments are the most dangerous of all. **However**, he never offers a boat or an escape; the poem ends with a question, not an answer. Because these three images grow out of one another, the message becomes clear: man is carried by time and can never carry it.

Two transitions used: “As a result”, “Moreover”, “However”. Two sentence structures used: a compound sentence (“Shelley first presents... and he then shows...”) and a complex sentence (“Because these three images grow out of one another...”).

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H. Precise Language, Metaphor, Simile and Analogy

Precise language means clear, specific and accurate words. **Domain-specific vocabulary** means the words of one subject area — for time: chronological, duration, fleeting, ebb, mortality. **Metaphor** says that one thing is another (Time is a thief). **Simile** compares using “like” or “as” (Time is like a river). **Analogy** is an extended comparison to explain an idea (time is like sand slipping through the fingers).

1. What metaphor does the poet use in “Time” to describe time? How does this help you understand the poem's message?

He uses the metaphor of an **unfathomable sea** — “Ocean of Time”. This helps in three ways. It makes an invisible thing **visible** (we can picture the sea), it makes it **measurable in one respect only** (we can see waves but never the bottom, which is exactly our knowledge of time), and it makes the message **emotional**: a sea can drown a swimmer, so the reader feels that time is a danger and not a friend. The metaphor therefore carries the whole message — time is vast, deep, merciless and impossible to cross.

2. Write your own metaphor or simile to describe how time feels during exams or on your birthday.

During exams: Time is a strict invigilator who walks up and down the hall and never once looks at my paper. (metaphor) / Time during exams is like water in a fist — the harder I squeeze, the faster it runs away. (simile)

On my birthday: My birthday is a fast train that stops for one minute and leaves before I have found my seat. (metaphor) / A birthday feels like a page that turns by itself, whether or not I have finished reading it. (simile)

3. What are two features of formal style you should remember when writing an essay about a poem?

(i) Complete, impersonal sentences with no slang and no contractions: write “The poet does not offer any solution”, not “The poet doesn't give any way out”. **(ii) Textual evidence in a formal manner:** quote the exact words of the poem and analyse them — “The phrase ‘brackish with the salt of human tears’ shows that…” — instead of giving a personal reaction only. A third feature is the use of precise literary terms (metaphor, personification, tone) in place of vague praise like “very nice”.

4. Why is it important to keep an objective tone when analysing literature? How does it help your reader trust your interpretation?

An objective tone means staying neutral and basing every claim on the text rather than on personal feelings. It is important because literature can be read in more than one way, so an analysis must show **evidence**, not opinion. When a writer says “The word ‘howling’ makes time sound like a hungry animal, which creates a tone of fear”, the reader can check the word himself and agree. When he says only “the poem is very scary and I hated it”, the reader learns nothing and cannot trust the judgement. Objectivity therefore makes the interpretation **verifiable**, and verifiable writing is what earns marks and respect.

I. Oral Communication Skills — Panel Discussion

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1. Do you think Shelley's portrayal of time as a destructive and uncontrollable force reflects how most people experience time in real life? Why or why not?

For the statement: most people do feel time exactly as Shelley describes it. A farmer waits for rain that never comes and loses a whole year; a student finds that the examination arrives before the syllabus is finished; a family loses an elder and learns how quickly a life closes. In such moments time appears as a flood that no one can stop, and the “treacherous in calm” line fits the quiet days in which we forget how fast the water is moving.

Against the statement: ordinary experience is not always so dark. Time can also be a builder: a patient student becomes a doctor in eight years, a small shop grows into a business, and a wound heals with time. For a believing person, time is a trust from Allah that can be used well, not only a sea that drowns. Moreover, a poem exaggerates on purpose — one dark image is not the whole truth about human life.

Balanced conclusion: Shelley's picture is true to the **power** of time and false to its **possibilities**. Time is uncontrollable, but our use of it is not. The healthiest view is to accept that the sea cannot be stopped and still to sail carefully — that is, to value every hour, do good work and remember our mortality.

J. Summary of the Poem

In “Time”, Percy Bysshe Shelley presents time as an “unfathomable sea” whose waves are years and whose water is brackish with the salt of human tears. It is a shoreless flood in whose ebb and flow the whole of human mortality is held. Like a beast sick of prey yet still howling for more, it throws up the wrecks of human lives on an inhospitable shore, and it is treacherous in calm and terrible in storm. The poem closes with a rhetorical question — who can sail on this unfathomable sea? — and the implied answer is nobody. The tone is dark, reflective and awe-filled, and the message is that humanity is helpless before the relentless, destructive passage of time.

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Points to Remember

• Poet: Percy Bysshe Shelley (1792–1822), English Romantic poet; also wrote "Ozymandias" and "To a Skylark".

• Central metaphor: time = unfathomable sea. Its waves = years; its water = human tears (brackish).

• Key phrases: shoreless flood, claspest the limits of mortality, sick of prey yet howling on for more, vomitest thy wrecks, treacherous in calm, terrible in storm.

• Figures of speech: metaphor (sea of time), personification (howling, sick of prey), apostrophe (Unfathomable Sea!), rhetorical question (Who shall put forth on thee?).

• Tone: dark, mournful, awe-filled. Theme: the power of time and the helplessness of man before mortality.

• Glossary: brackish, claspest, ebb, howling, shoreless, treacherous, unfathomable, vomitest, woe. The endings -est/-eth are archaic forms.

• Precis: a much shorter restatement of the main idea in your own words, without figurative language or personal opinion.

• Metaphor = is; simile = like/as; analogy = extended comparison; formal style = no slang, no contractions, textual evidence.

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